

Open Source for Career Management

Most human resource consulting firms face challenges in presenting the right candidates for right jobs. Monster.com's advert, "Caught in a wrong job", clearly outlines those challenges. Here is a case study that outlines how Open Source assists professionals in getting that coveted job.

Executive Track Associates (ETA) is a search and recruitment consulting firm with its headquarters in Delhi. It has offices in seven different locations in India—New Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai, Coimbatore, Hyderabad, Pune and Bangalore. Founded by Adarsh Matta, an engineer and alumnus of IIM-Ahmedabad, ETA works not only to provide services to its clients but also helps them to find the right fit. According to sources in the company, it provides executive solutions to clients including multinationals, entrepreneurial businesses, private equity firms, etc.

With its multiple locations and vast spread of verticals, associates at ETA faced a multitude of challenges:

- CV data was scattered in desktop mailboxes spread across the country.
- Classification, storage and retrieval of this data was a major effort.
- Just-in-time availability of the right CV was a challenge.
- Required information flow pertaining to placed candidates was a challenge.
- Moreover, advertisements in print and electronic media would result in a huge inflow of CVs, making the task of handling this vital information very cumbersome.

ETA decided that a central data repository of CVs would be the best option whereby searching the repository would be quick and yield useful information which could easily be converted to revenue.

Security was a major concern. This data bank would contain important confidential data and should not be accessible to anyone apart from authorised users. Moreover, most emails containing CVs could also be potential sources for viruses. They also did not want proprietary lock-in so that they would have to be dependant on a

single vendor for any change in the application.

They had evaluated various software options available, but none could properly address their concern on security and vendor lock-in, though a few promised extra functionality and features.

Discussing his thoughts with a colleague, Matta was suggested the open source way and referred to Varad Gupta, CTO of Keen & Able Computers Pvt Ltd, a Delhi-based IT-implementation firm that provides open source solutions to its clients. Gupta, an avid believer in the open source model comments, "Open source was the only option that I could suggest to Mr Matta. He wanted the most secure platforms at affordable costs. He wanted an IT setup which would work, rather than invest in an IT team that did most of the work. He wanted performance and reliability affordably. He wanted security from external threats and viruses and most importantly he wanted scalability without any hidden license costs. We suggested an open source model for his infrastructure and application requirements—Human Resource Management System (HRMS)."

In HRMS, the critical area of concern was the data inflow, and classification for quick access and retrieval when desired, for authorised users only. An end-to-end solution, HRMS comprises of the following:

- Mail server (to receive incoming mails, remove viruses and spam)
- VPN servers and clients (to enable site-to-site VPN within various ETA branch offices)
- Application portal for classifying, storage and search
- Reliability and redundancy of centralised data which should be available whenever desired by an authorised user.

HRMS can be implemented in various ways depending on the requirements. It includes functionalities such as payroll management,